

Psalms 95

Harden Not Your Hearts

To day if ye will hear his voice, harden not your heart
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *O come, let us sing unto the LORD: let us make a joyful noise to the rock of our salvation.*
- 2 *Let us come before his presence with thanksgiving, and make a joyful noise unto him with psalms.*
- 3 *For the LORD is a great God, and a great King above all gods.*
- 4 *In his hand are the deep places of the earth: the strength of the hills is his also.*
- 5 *The sea is his, and he made it: and his hands formed the dry land.*
- 6 *O come, let us worship and bow down: let us kneel before the LORD our maker.*
- 7 *For he is our God; and we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand. To day if ye will hear his voice,*
- 8 *Harden not your heart, as in the provocation, and as in the day of temptation in the wilderness:*
- 9 *When your fathers tempted me, proved me, and saw my work.*
- 10 *Forty years long was I grieved with this generation, and said, It is a people that do err in their heart, and they have not known my ways:*
- 11 *Unto whom I swear in my wrath that they should not enter into my rest.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 95 moves from exuberant summons to worship into a sober warning drawn from Israel's wilderness failure at Meribah and Massah, where the fathers tested God despite having seen His works firsthand. Hebrews 3–4 later builds an extended argument on this psalm's closing verses, using it to warn believers against the same hardened unbelief. Henry treats the pairing of praise and warning as deliberate: genuine worship and genuine self-examination belong together, not in separate compartments.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-5

The call to worship is full-throated: come, sing, make a joyful noise to the rock of salvation, come before His presence with thanksgiving, make a joyful noise with psalms. The reasoning is theological and cosmic—the Lord is a great God, a great King above all gods, holding the sea and dry land, the deep places of the earth and the strength of the hills, all as His own handiwork.

Verse 6-7

Worship narrows from noise to posture: come, worship, bow down, kneel before the Lord our maker. The relationship is described tenderly—we are His people, the sheep of His hand—immediately followed by the pivotal condition: today, if you will hear His voice.

Verse 8-11

The warning turns to history: harden not your heart as at Meribah, as in the day of temptation in the wilderness, when the fathers tested and proved God despite having seen His work. God's grief over that generation is stated plainly—forty years grieved with a generation whose hearts continually erred, who did not know His ways—leading to the sworn consequence that they would not enter His rest.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine worship is inseparable from genuine responsiveness to God's voice in the present moment; it is possible to sing loudly about God's greatness while simultaneously hardening one's heart against what He is actually saying today. Israel's wilderness generation serves as a permanent warning that having witnessed God's works firsthand is no guarantee against unbelief—the danger is ongoing, not merely historical.

Application for life today.

As you worship, ask honestly whether there is a specific area where you are currently 'hardening your heart' against something God has been saying—resist letting loud praise substitute for actual responsiveness. Take the psalm's urgency literally: the warning is for 'today,' not someday, so name the delay or resistance you are currently practicing and bring it to God now. Let Israel's

example humble any confidence that having seen God work before makes you immune to hardening in the present.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where might you currently be 'hardening your heart' against something God has been saying, even while continuing to worship outwardly (vv. 7–8)?

2. How does the emphasis on 'today' (v. 7) challenge any tendency you have to postpone responding to God until a more convenient time?

3. What does Israel's wilderness failure—despite having witnessed God's works firsthand (v. 9)—warn you about assuming your own past experience of God guarantees present faithfulness?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).